



JOHN MUIR High Principal Lawton Gray, left, greets his former Muir classmate and district lead gardener Juan Villegas.

Photographs by MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

Gardener overcomes dual shocks to help reopen Pasadena schools

First, Juan Villegas’ father died. Then, wildfire burned in-laws’ house and campuses he tended.

BY DANIEL MILLER

Juan Villegas’ community was still burning on the afternoon of Jan. 8. But there was one place he had to get to: Eliot Arts Magnet Academy, his alma mater. The Pasadena middle school had welcomed Villegas as a 12-year-old from Mexico. It’s where he found his footing in a strange new country, connecting with other Latino immigrants and making lifelong friends. He’d heard the campus had been destroyed, but rumors traveled fast during the initial hours of the Eaton fire. Someone had told him that Super King Market on Lincoln Avenue had burned, but that had turned out to be wrong. Maybe, somehow, the school was OK. Roads near Eliot were closed. But Villegas knew a way around the Lincoln Avenue closure. He passed through residential neighborhoods, where flames still spewed from the severed gas lines of smoldering homes, and ash rained from the sky.

[See [Gardener](#), A9]



VILLEGAS fixes a chain saw before cleaning up Muir High on Feb. 5. He went there in the 1990s but left his senior year to care for his grandfather.

SCHOOLS ORDERED TO GET RID OF ALL DEI

Trump administration threatens to cut U.S. funding if programs are not shut down.

BY JAWEED KALEEM

The U.S. Department of Education has given colleges and schools with race-specific programs — including financial aid and racially themed dormitory floors and graduation ceremonies — until the end of the month to abolish them or risk losing federal funding as educators scrambled over the holiday weekend to interpret the sweeping scope of new guidelines.

The “dear colleague” letter from the department’s civil rights division addressed to K-12 and higher education leaders lays out a new federal anti-discrimination enforcement policy that extends beyond the use of race in admissions, a practice barred since 2023 by the U.S. Supreme Court.

The guidelines, signed by acting assistant secretary for civil rights Craig Trainor, said schools using “race in decisions pertaining to admissions, hiring, promotion, compensation, financial aid, scholarships, prizes, administrative support, discipline, housing, graduation ceremonies, and all other aspects of student, academic, and campus life” were in violation of anti-discrimination laws and legal precedent set [See [Schools](#), A6]

State may get in oil refining business

A takeover is among options to ensure supply as gasoline producers pull back.

BY RUSS MITCHELL

Russia. China. Venezuela. Iran. More than a dozen countries make gasoline at state-owned refineries.

Could California be next on the list?

California policymakers are considering state ownership of one or more oil refineries, one item on a list of options presented by the California Energy Commission to ensure steady gas supplies as oil companies pull back from the refinery business in the state.

“The state recognizes that they’re on a pathway to more refinery closures,” said Skip York, chief energy strategist at energy consultant Turner Mason & Co. The risk to consumers and the state’s economy, he said, is gasoline supply disappearing faster than consumer demand, resulting in fuel shortages, higher prices and severe logistical challenges.

Gasoline demand is falling in California, albeit slowly, for two reasons: more efficient gasoline engines, and the increasing number [See [Refineries](#), A6]

‘Prophet of doom’? No, he saw a different L.A.

Mike Davis predicted disasters, but he was preparing the way for who would save city: us

GUSTAVO ARELLANO

Hellish wildfires. Whiplash weather. Destructive winds. Debris flows. Torrential rains accenting punishing droughts.

Welcome to the Los Angeles Mike Davis predicted.

The late urbanist first made waves in the 1990s for forecasting an L.A. that would be one ecological and man-made disaster after another. His work quickly made him controversial among civic boosters, who dismissed him as a negative nabob who didn’t want the city to thrive.

Today, Davis is one face on the Mt. Rushmore of L.A.’s prophets, alongside Joan Didion, Carey McWilliams and Octavia Butler.

His words, more than anyone else’s, have been cited by writers and pundits across the world in this



ADAM PEREZ For The Times

THE WRITINGS of the late urbanist Mike Davis were cris de coeur more than lamentations, Gustavo Arellano writes.

annus horribilis where nothing seems to be going right and everything seems to be getting worse.

With respect to his fellow titans, none of them ever assailed the poultry industry for bragging about reaping “profit from the influenza-driven restructuring of global chicken production.” That’s exactly what Davis wrote in a 2006 book warning about the threat of avian flu, complete with a photo of a menacing white rooster on the cover.

Davis is the man of the moment, the person whose work all Angelenos should parse like a secular Talmud — but his premonitions of hellfire and brimstone aren’t what we should heed most.

The rest of the nation has eagerly waited for Los Angeles to collapse into tribal warfare and anarchy the moment a mega-catastrophe happened. If ever there was a time for that, it would be now, after the [See [Arellano](#), A5]

Talks on Ukraine without Ukraine

Russia and U.S. officials will hold their most significant meeting since the invasion. **WORLD, A3**

Snell is making time for Miller

Cy Young winner is mentoring the young pitcher at Dodgers camp. **SPORTS, B10**

A 97-year-old nursery is closing

Two brothers who run a Hawthorne business full of local history are retiring. **BUSINESS, A8**

Weather

Turning sunny.

L.A. Basin: 66/49. **B6**

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